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Kanye West Dropped by CAA, Doc Canceled Following Antisemitic Remarks

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Superstar rapper Kanye "Ye" West has been dropped by Creative Artists Agency (CAA) and a planned documentary has been canceled, as the fallout continues over his antisemitic remarks.

West has come under fire after tweeting that he was going to go "death con 3" against the Jews after he was locked out of his Instagram account. West doubled down on his remarks in an October 15 appearance on the Drink Champs podcast; a couple days later, he said in an interview with Chris Cuomo that his "death con 3" remarks were referencing "Jewish record labels" taking "ownership" of Black musicians. West proceeded to defend his remarks in a subsequent interview with Piers Morgan, going as far as calling Morgan a "Karen" before eventually saying he's "sorry for the people I hurt" after posting the "death con 3" tweet.

The Los Angeles Times first reported the CAA news on October 24; the agency had been representing him since 2016. The Times report did not specify the exact date on which the agency dropped West, only that it had happened some time in October.

MRC, the studio behind West's documentary, announced in an October 24 memo that they will not be moving forward with West's documentary, per Variety. "We cannot support any content that amplifies his platform," the memo stated. "Kanye is a producer and sampler of music. Last week he sampled and remixed a classic tune that has charted for over 3,000 years—the lie that Jews are evil and conspire to control the world for their own gain. The silence from leaders and corporations when it comes to Kanye or antisemitism in general is dismaying but not surprising. What is new and sad, is the fear Jews have about speaking out in their own defense."

West has also been dropped by the fashion company Balenciaga and Vogue Editor-In-Chief Anna Wintour has also cut all professional ties with the rapper.

"Thank you, CAA," Anti-Defamation League CEO Jonathan Greenblatt tweeted. "Thank you for demonstrating what a business can and should do in response to Ye's antisemitic comments. @adidas, are you going to be next?"

Associate Dean and Director of Global Social Action Agenda at the Simon Wiesenthal Center Rabbi Abraham Cooper told the Journal that if West "wants to remain the billionaire antisemite, CAA did exactly the right thing. There needs to be a public price for bigotry."

Stop Antisemitism similarly tweeted, "We applaud CAA and MRC on their decision and call on Adidas to follow suit."

The American Jewish Committee tweeted that "silence is complicity." "Any companies working with Kanye or Yeezy, any celebrities endorsing him or his garments, or any artists collaborating with him need to know the effect that their actions have," they tweeted. "Take a principled stand against hate."

An effort has been under way to get Adidas to end its partnership with West. The ADL's Greenblatt wrote a letter to the company on October 20 noting that they had said their relationship with the rapper was "under review" after West was photographed wearing a "White Lives Matter" shirt. "At this point, what more do you need to review?" Greenblatt asked. "We were particularly alarmed to see that the Adidas brand intends to release new products in the Yeezy line, including the Yeezy Boost 350, in the run-up to the anniversary of the Pittsburgh synagogue massacre on Oct. 27—the most violent antisemitic attack in U.S. history."

Greenblatt went on to call West's comments "dangerous" amidst rising antisemitism worldwide. "Many other celebrities, as well as some corporations and pundits have joined ADL in calling out his hateful rhetoric. We hope

that more companies, individuals, and political leaders will take action to show that there will be consequences for such hateful rhetoric and that they do not give Ye's antisemitism a pass," he wrote. "This is why we are surprised and concerned that Adidas—a brand that supports inclusion and diversity—continues not only to support the Ye product line, but to release new products even as he continues to espouse hateful antisemitic ideas to his 31 million Twitter followers, and as those noxious ideas spread across social media and around the world thanks to his outsized media presence and celebrity status."

Greenblatt told The Washington Post on October 24 that he has since had conversations with the various higher-ups at Adidas but was not pleased with their responses. "At this point we are kind of flummoxed how Adidas has dropped the ball and failed to make a clear and cogent statement about their values," Greenblatt said. "Antisemitism should be unacceptable in any circumstance," he said. "The fact that Adidas has not made that simple point is shocking when one considers Adidas's history as a company that once outfitted the Hitler Youth."

California Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-San Fernando Valley) and State Senator Scott Wiener (D-San Francisco) also called for Adidas to drop West. "Words have consequences," they said in a statement. "Kanye West threatened Jews, and now other extremists are openly threatening our Jewish community with hateful banners on the 405 freeway and distributing appalling antisemitic propaganda in our neighborhoods."

The "extremists" referenced by Gabriel and Wiener are in the white supremacist organization Goyim Defense League. "We are proud to be Jewish and we will not remain silent when hatred and bigotry are openly directed at our Jewish community or any other community in California," Gabriel and Wiener continued. "Any company—including Adidas—that continues to do business with Kanye West is party to this attack on Jews. It is morally indefensible to turn a blind eye to antisemitism and to put profits over the safety of Jews or others targeted by hate. We are grateful to those who have spoken out in solidarity with our Jewish community. Together, we will build a stronger and safer state."

Even Jewish Voice for Peace-Los Angeles (JVP-LA), an organization that supports the Boycott, Divestment and Sanctions movement, issued a statement condemning "the recent acts of antisemitism in Los Angeles. As an anti-racist organization, JVP-LA understands that real safety and security are only achieved through solidarity. JVP-LA condemns these instances of antisemitism as it condemns all racism and all incidents of hate."

Various celebrities have also called for Adidas to sever ties with West. "Friends" star David Schwimmer posted a video on Instagram expressing support for Greenblatt and echoed their call for Adidas to "#RunAwayFromHate." Other Hollywood celebrities urging Adidas to end their ties with West include Josh Gad, Kat Dennings and Valerie Bertinelli.

West has said on the Drink Champs podcast that "I can literally say antisemitic s— and [Adidas] cannot drop me. Now what? Now what?" CNBC reported that every time they have reached out to Adidas for comment, their response has simply been that their relationship with West is "under review."

The post Kanye West Dropped by CAA, Doc Canceled Following Antisemitic Remarks appeared first on Jewish Journal.

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